

Early Christian art

By 313 CE, Christianity had become so powerful that Emperor Constantine (c.272–337) converted on his deathbed. By 380, it was the official religion of the Roman Empire, but by then the Empire had split; the West was still ruled from Rome, but the centre of power had shifted to Byzantium, now renamed Constantinople. Expressed in frescoes, mosaics, sculpture and manuscript illumination, the religion's first art almost exclusively portrayed Bible stories. Some second-century wall and ceiling paintings in the Roman catacombs (underground burial chambers) are the earliest identifiably Christian art.

A great deal of early Christian art borrowed from pagan Roman traditions and styles, which in turn had developed from Greek pagan art. During the third and fourth centuries, Christian figures were manifestations of earlier pagan models. For instance, early images of Jesus follow the Greek representations of Apollo. Gradually the art developed its own identity, since unlike much Greek art, its ideal was not physical beauty but spiritual feeling.



Ceiling of the San Vitale Basilica, Ravenna, 547 CE